'gang of four' (all Khalqi stalwarts) Sarwari had planned and executed the assassination of another fellow Khalqi—former Afghan president Hafizullah Amin.[4]

Making way for a jittery Soviet Union to send troops to Afghanistan in 1979, Sarwari also paved the way for the rise of his Parchami adversary, Babrak Karmal, as the president. In a move to reconcile the two factions, Moscow arbitrated a deal in which Karmal accepted Sarwari as his second in command for a brief period.[5] Counting on an early Soviet exit, which he expected would leave Karmal weak and susceptible, Sarwari continued his internal struggle against his Parchami comrades, and cracked down on Islamist dissidents and their families, shooting some dead and burying others alive.[6] In an attempt to deal with Sarwari without further bloodshed, Karmal eased him out within months of coming to power by appointing him as Afghanistan's ambassador to Mongolia in 1980, a position he held for six years, and removing him from politburo in 1981. In 1986, Sarwari's membership of the PDPA Central Committee was annulled and he was ordered to go to Germany, followed by an ambassadorial position in South Yemen.

By 1987, Sarwari's hopes of coming to power had been crushed by Parcham's Mohammad Najibullah, another communist spymaster who became president. Not shy to use force whenever the need arose (his preferred technique to execute prisoners was to beat them to the ground and then kick them to death), Najibullah was a tough match for Sarwari and his allies.[7] Najibullah got along well with the Soviet Union and consummately practiced the craft of inter-tribal manipulation and rivalry. However, politically and structurally, his government was far weaker than its predecessor. With the Soviets crawling out of Afghanistan and the Mujahideen offensive in full swing (via Pakistan), Najibullah's political situation was becoming increasingly precarious by early 1990. That is when Sarwari decided to end his diplomatic exile in South Yemen and join Najibullah's disgruntled chief of army staff and a fellow Khalqi, Lt. Gen. Shahnawaz Tanai. Angry at Najibullah's pro-Parcham bias, Tanai had secretly made plans with help from the Mujahideen based in Pakistan, to overthrow Najibullah.[8] But then, Sarwari's life took an unexpected, ugly turn.